

The Hidden Curriculum and the Nature of Conflict

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There has been, so far, little examination of how the treatment of conflict in the school curriculum can lead to political quiescence and the acceptance by students of a perspective on social and intellectual conflict that acts to maintain the existing distribution of power and rationality in a society. This paper examines two areas—social studies and science—to indicate how an unrealistic and basically consensus-oriented perspective is taught through a “hidden curriculum” in schools. The argument centers around the fundamental place that forms of conflict have had in science and the social world and on the necessity of such conflict. The paper suggests that a greater emphasis in the school curriculum upon the ideal norms of science, e.g., organized skepticism, and on the uses of conflict could counterbalance the tacit assumptions being taught.

On n'a guère étudié jusqu'à présent comment la façon d'aborder le problème des incompatibilités dans le programme d'études peut contribuer à la paix politique et à l'acceptation par les étudiants d'une certaine perspective du conflit social et intellectuel qui contribue à la préservation de l'actuelle répartition de l'autorité et de la rationalité au sein d'une société. La présente communication étudie les deux domaines des sciences humaines et des sciences pures pour souligner comment, par le truchement d'un “programme d'études camouflé,” on enseigne dans les écoles une attitude qui manque de réalisme et qui est essentiellement fondée sur la notion d'unanimité. Le raisonnement de l'auteur se fonde surtout sur la position fondamentale qu'occupent certaines formes de conflit dans le domaine de la science et des problèmes sociaux et sur l'utilité de tels conflits. L'auteur estime que l'on pourrait faire contrepoids aux hypothèses tacites enseignées à l'heure actuelle, en mettant dans les programmes scolaires davantage l'accent sur les normes scientifiques idéales, autrement dit sur un scepticisme méthodique et sur les avantages des conflits en question.

Conflict and the Hidden Curriculum

The fact that schools are usually *overtly* insulated from political processes and ideological argumentation has both positive and negative qualities. The insulation has served to defend the school against whims and fads that can often have a destructive effect upon educational practice. It also, however, can make the school rather unresponsive to the needs of local communities and a changing social order. The pros and cons of the school as a “conservative” institution have been argued fervently for the last 10 years or so, at least. Among the most articulate of the spokesmen have been Edgar Z. Friedenberg and the late Jules Henry. The covert teaching of an achievement and marketplace ethic and the probable substitution of a “middle-class” and often “schizophrenic” value system for a student's own biographical meanings are the topics most usually subject to analysis. A good deal of the focus has been on what Jackson (1968) has so felicitously labeled the “hidden curriculum”—that is, on the norms and values that are implicitly, but effectively, taught in schools and that are not usually talked about in teachers' statements of end or goals. Jackson (pp.3-37), for instance, deals extensively with the way students learn to cope with the systems of crowds, praise, and power in classrooms: with the large amount of waiting children are called upon to experience, with the teacher as a child's first “boss,” and how children learn to falsify certain aspects of their behavior to conform to the reward system extant in most classrooms.

These critiques of the world-view being legitimated in the schools have been incisive, yet they have failed to focus on a prevailing characteristic of current schooling that significantly contributes to the maintenance of the same dominant world-view. There has been, so far, little examination of how the treatment of *conflict* in the school curriculum can lead to political quiescence and the acceptance by students of a perspective on social and intellectual conflict that acts to maintain the existing distribution of power and rationality in a society. The topic of conflict is crucial for two reasons. How it is dealt with helps to posit a student's sense of the legitimate means of gaining recourse within industrial societies. This is particularly important, and will become more so, in urban areas. It may be rather imperative that urban students develop positive perspectives toward conflict and change, ones that will enable them to deal with the complex and often re-

pressive political realities and dynamics of power of their society in a manner less apt to preserve current institutional modes of interaction (cf. Eisinger, 1970). Also, there may well be specific programmatic suggestions that can be made and instituted fairly readily in ongoing school programs that may alleviate some of the problems.

We can learn a bit about the importance of tacit or hidden teaching from the literature on political socialization. It is beginning to be clear that "incidental learning" contributes more to the political socialization of a student than do, say, civics classes or other forms of deliberate teaching of specific value orientations (Sigel, 1970, p.xiii). Children are taught how to deal with and relate to the structures of authority of the collectivity to which they belong by the patterns of interaction they are exposed to to a certain extent in schools.

Obviously, it is not only the school that contributes to a student's "adjustment to authority." For instance, peer groups and especially the family, through its child-rearing practices and its style of interpersonal interaction, can profoundly affect a child's general orientation to authority (Sigel, p.105). However, there is a strong suggestion in recent research that schools are rather close rivals to the family as significant agents of political socialization. As Sigel (p.316) puts it:

"[There] is probably little doubt that the public schools are a choice transmission belt for the traditional rather than the innovative, much less the radical. As a result, they facilitate the political socialization of the mainstream young and tend to equip them with the tools necessary for the particular roles they are expected to play in a given society. One may wish to quarrel with the differential roles the government and the schools assign to students, but it would probably be considerably more difficult to deny the school's effectiveness."¹

¹ Such a statement is both realistic and rather critical. In a way, critics of the schools (and the present author to a large extent) are caught in a bind. It is rather easy to denigrate existing "educational" structures (after all, everyone seems to do it); yet, it is not quite as easy to offer alternative structures. The individual who attempts to ameliorate some of the more debilitating conditions runs the risk of actually helping to shore up and perpetuate what may very well be an outmoded set of institutional arrangements. Yet, not to try to better conditions in what are often small and stumbling ways is to neglect those real human beings who now inhabit the schools for most of their pre-adult lives. Therefore, one

It should be stated that the negative treatment given to the uses of conflict goes far beyond the way with which it is overtly dealt in any one subject, say, social studies, the area in which one usually finds material on and teaching about conflict situations. Rather, the negative and quite unrealistic approach seems endemic to many areas, and especially to science, the area usually associated with objectivity and noninterpersonal conflict.

It has become increasingly evident that history books and social studies texts and materials have, over the years, presented a somewhat biased view of the true nature of the amount and possible use of internecine strife in which groups in this country and others have engaged. Our side is good; their side is bad. "We" are peace loving and want an end to strife; "they" are warlike and aim to dominate. The list could be extended considerably especially in racial matters (Gibson, 1969; Willhelm, 1970). Yet, we must go beyond this type of analysis, often even beyond the work of the revisionist historians, political scientists, students of political socialization, and educators to get at many of the roots of the teaching of this dominant orientation. We examine here two specific areas—social studies and science. In so doing, we point out that the presentation of these two areas (among others) in schools both mirrors and fosters an ideology that is oriented to a static perspective: in the social studies, on the positive and even essential functions of social conflict; and in science, on the nature of scientific work and argumentation and on what has been called "revolutionary" science. The view presented of science, especially, in the schools is particularly interesting since it is essentially an archetype of the ideological position on conflict we wish to illuminate.

Two tacit assumptions seem to be prominent in teaching and in curricular materials. The first centers around a negative position on the nature and uses of conflict. The second focuses on man as a recipient of

tries to play both sides of the battle often. One criticizes the fundamental assumptions that undergird schools as they exist today and, at the same time, paradoxically attempts to make these same institutions a bit more humane, a bit more educative. It is an ambiguous position, but, after all, so is one's total situation. Our discussion of the fundamental glossing over of the nature and necessity of conflict and the tacit teaching that accompanies it shows this ambiguity. However, if urban education in particular is to make a difference (and here we should read politically and economically), then concrete changes must be effected now *while* the more basic criticisms are themselves being articulated. One is not an excuse for the other.

values and institutions, not on man as a creator and recreator of values and institutions. These assumptions act as basic guidelines that order experiences.

Basic Rules and Tacit Assumptions

Fundamental patterns in society are held together by tacit assumptions, rules if you will, which are not usually conscious. These rules serve to organize and legitimate the activity of the many individuals whose interaction makes up a social order. Analytically it is helpful to distinguish two types of rules—constitutive or basic rules and preference rules (McClure & Fischer, 1969). Basic rules are like the rules of a game; they are broad parameters in which action takes place. Preference rules, as the name suggests, are the choices one has within the rules of the game. Take chess, for instance. There are basic ground rules (which are not usually brought to a level of awareness) that make chess different from, say, checkers or other board games or even nonboard games. And, within the game of chess, one has choices of the moves to make within this constitutive framework. Pawns' choices involve moving forward (except in "taking" an opponent), rooks move forward or side-to-side, and so forth. If an opponent's pawn were to jump over three men to put you in check, then he obviously would not be following the "rules of the game"; nor would he be following the tacitly accepted rules if he, say, swept all your men from the board and shouted "I win!"

On the very broadest level, one of the constitutive rules most predominant in our society involves the notion of trust. When we drive down the street, we trust that the car approaching from the opposite direction will stay in its lane. Unless there is some outward manifestation of deviance from this rule, we never even bring to a level of conscious awareness how this basic rule of activity organizes our lives.² A similar

rule is the one that posits the legitimate bounds of conflict. The rules of the game implicitly set out the boundaries of the activities people are to engage or not to engage in, the types of questions to ask, and the acceptance or rejection of other people's activities.³ Within these boundaries, there are choices among a range of activities. We can use the courts, but not bomb; we can argue, but not duel; and so forth. A basic assumption seems to be that conflict among groups of people is *inherently* and fundamentally bad and we should strive to eliminate it *within* the established framework of institutions.

Clearly, my critique is not an attempt to impugn the motives or integrity of schools. Some of the better schools and classrooms are alive with issues and controversy. However, the controversies usually exhibited in schools concern choices *within* the parameters of implicitly held rules of activity. Little attempt is made to focus on the parameters themselves.

The hidden curriculum in schools serves to reinforce basic rules surrounding the nature of conflict and its uses. It posits a network of assumptions that, when internalized by students, establishes the boundaries of legitimacy. This process is accomplished not so much by explicit instances showing the negative value of conflict, but by nearly the total absence of instances showing the importance of intellectual and normative conflict in subject areas. The fact is that these assumptions are *obligatory* for the students, since at no time are the assumptions articulated or questioned. By the very fact that they are tacit, their potency is enlarged.⁴

The potent relationship between basic assumptions dominant in a collectivity and the hidden curriculum of school is examined by Dreeben (1968). He argues that students tacitly learn certain identifiable social

² The language of "rules of activity" is less analytically troublesome than the distinction often made between thought and action, since it implies that the distinction is somewhat naive and enables action, perceptual, conceptual, and bodily, to be the fundamental category of an individual's response to his situation. While we often use rules of activity and assumptions interchangeably, the point should be made that assumptions usually connote a less inclusive category of phenomena and are actually indicative of the existence of these socially sedimented rules and boundaries that seem to affect even our very perceptions. Further work on such rules can be found in the ethnomethodological literature (Garfinkel, 1967) and, of course, in the later Wittgenstein (1958).

³ In essence, the "system" that many individuals decry is *not* an ordered interrelationship of institutions, but a framework of fundamental assumptions that are prior to and act in a dialectical relationship with these institutions.

⁴ The questions we are posing can obviously lead to a circular type of controversy. Do the children learn, say, political quiescence and acceptance in school and then transfer these to life in general, or do the schools "merely" reinforce constitutive rules learned elsewhere? This is not the point (though it is, no doubt, quite important). What is more important is to at least begin to ask *how* the schools may function, through the hidden curriculum, to obligate and reinforce the learning by children of a certain perspective.

norms mainly by coping with the day-to-day encounters and tasks of classroom life. The fact that these norms that students learn penetrate many areas of later life is critical since it helps document how schooling contributes to individual adjustment to an ongoing social, economic, and political order. Schooling, occupation, and politics in the United States are well integrated for Dreeben (pp.144-145). The former acts as a distributor of a form of rationality that, when internalized by the student, enables him to function in and, often, accept "the occupational and political institutions which contribute to the stability of an industrial society."

Social studies and science as they are taught in the large majority of schools provide some of the most explicit instances of the hidden teaching. We have chosen these areas for two reasons. First, there has been built up a rather extensive and important literature concerned with the sociology of the disciplines of scientific endeavor. This literature deals rather insightfully with the "logic-in-use" of scientists (that is, what scientists seem actually to do) as opposed to the "reconstructed logic" of scientists (that is, what philosophers of science and other observers say scientists do) that is normally taught in schools (Apple, in press). Second, in social studies the problems we discuss can be illuminated rather clearly by drawing upon selected Marxian notions (ideas, not necessarily dogma) to show that the common-sense views of social life often found in the teaching of social studies are not inevitable. Let us examine science initially. In so doing, we propose an alternate or, rather, a broader view of scientific endeavor that should be considered by educators and, especially, curriculum workers, if they are, at the very least, to focus on the assumptions inherent in much that is taught in our educational institutions.

Conflict in Scientific Communities

One of our basic theses is that science, as it is presented in most elementary and a large proportion of secondary classrooms, contributes to the learning by students of a basically unrealistic and essentially conservative perspective on the usefulness of conflict. Scientific domains are presented as bodies of knowledge ("that's" and "how's"), at best organized around certain fundamental regularities as in the many discipline and inquiry-centered curricula that evolved after the "Brunerian revolution," at worst as fairly isolated data one masters for tests. Almost never is it seriously

examined as a personal construction of human beings. Let us examine this situation rather closely.

A science is not "just" a domain of knowledge or techniques of discovery and formulating justifications; it is a *group* (or rather, groups) of individuals, a *community* of scholars in Polanyi's (1964) terms, pursuing projects in the world. Like all communities, it is governed by norms, values, and principles that are both overtly seen and covertly felt. By being made up of individuals and groups of scholars, it also has had a significant history of both intellectual and interpersonal struggle. Often the conflict is generated by the introduction of a new and usually quite revolutionary paradigm that challenges the basic meaning structures that were previously accepted by the particular body of scientists, often, thereby, effectively dividing the scholarly community. These struggles have been concerned with the modes of gaining warranted knowledge, with what is to be considered properly scientific, with the very basic foundations upon which science is based. They have also been concerned with such situations as conflicting interpretations of data, with who discovered what first, and many more.

What can be found in schools, however, is a perspective that is akin to what has been called the *positivist ideal* (Hagstrom, 1965, p.256). In our schools, scientific work is tacitly always linked with accepted standards of validity and is seen (and taught) as always subject to empirical verification with no outside influences, either personal or political. "Schools of thought" in science do not exist or, if they do, "objective" criteria are used to persuade scientists that one side is correct and the other wrong. Just as is evident in our discussion of social studies instruction, children are presented with a *consensus theory of science*, one that underemphasizes the serious disagreements over methodology, goals, and other elements that make up the paradigms of activity of scientists. By the fact that scientific consensus is continually exhibited, students are not permitted to see that without disagreement and controversy science would not progress or would progress at a much slower pace. Not only does controversy stimulate discovery by drawing the attention of scientists to critical problems (Hagstrom, p.264), but it serves to clarify conflicting intellectual positions. More is mentioned about this point later in our discussion.

A point that is also quite potent is that it is very possible that the standards of "objectivity" (one is

tempted to say "vulgar objectivity") being exhibited and taught in school may often lead to a detachment from political commitment. That is, it may not be neutrality as it is overtly expressed, but it may mirror a rather deep fear of intellectual, moral, and political conflict (Gouldner, 1970, pp.102-103), and the personally intense commitment that coheres with the positions taken (Polanyi, 1964). The focus in educational institutions on the student/scientist (who is often a passive observer in many classrooms despite the emphasis being placed on inquiry by theorists and curriculum specialists) as an individual who objectively and rationally tests or deduces warranted assumptions or makes and checks hypotheses or what have you critically misrepresents the nature of the conflicts so often found between proponents of alternative solutions, interpretations, or modes of procedure in scientific communities. It cannot enable students to see the political dimension of the process by which one alternative theory's proponents win out over their competitors. Nor can such a presentation of science do more than systematically neglect the power dimension involved in scientific argumentation.

Not only is the historical and continuing conflict between competing theories in scientific domains ignored, but little or no thought has evidently been given to the fact that hypothesis-testing and the application of *existing* scientific criteria are *not sufficient* to explain how and why a choice is made between competing theories. There have been too many counter-instances that belie this view of science (Kuhn, 1962).⁵ It is much more perceptive to note that science itself is not necessarily cumulative, nor does it proceed according to a basic criterion of consensus, but that it is riven by conceptual revolutions that cause groups of scientists to reorganize and reconceptualize the models by which they attempt to understand and manipulate the world.

"The history of science has been and should be [seen] as a history of competing research programs (or, if you wish, 'paradigms'), but it has not been and must not become a succession of periods of normal science: the sooner competition starts the better for progress." (Lakatos, 1970, p.155)⁶

⁵ Kuhn's seminal work is subjected to rather acute analysis, and discussed with rebuttal and counter-rebuttal in Lakatos and Musgrave (1970). The entire volume is devoted to the issues, epistemological and sociological, raised by Kuhn's book.

We are not trying to make a case here for a view of science that states that "objectivity" and "neutrality," hypothesis-testing and inquiry procedures are not of paramount importance. What we are saying is that scientific argumentation and counter-argumentation are a major part of the scientific enterprise and that the theories and modes of procedure ("structures of disciplines," if you will) act as norms or psychological commitments that lead to intense controversy between groups of scientists (Apple, in press; Mulkay, 1969). This controversy is central to progress in science, and it is this continuing conflict that is hidden from students.

Perhaps this point can be made clearer by delving a bit more deeply into some of the realistic characteristics of scientific disciplines often hidden from public view and almost never taught in schools. We have been discussing conflict in scientific domains, yet it is difficult to separate conflict from competition.⁷ One of the more important oversights in schools is the lack of treatment whatsoever of the "problem" of competition in science. Competition over priority and recognition in new discoveries is a characteristic of *all* established sciences (Hagstrom, 1965, p.81). One need only read Watson's (1968) lively account of his race with Linus Pauling for the Nobel Prize for the discovery of the structure of DNA to realize how intense the competitiveness can be and how very human are scientists as individuals and in groups.

Competition also can be seen quite clearly between specialties in a discipline (Hagstrom, 1965, p.130), not necessarily on the "frontiers" of knowledge as in Watson's case. Here, as in football, the "commodity" (if I may speak metaphorically) is top-notch students who can be recruited to expand the power and prestige of an emerging specialty. There is continuous, but usually covert, competition among subdisciplines in science for what seem to be limited amounts of pres-

⁶ Normal science refers to that science that has agreement (consensus) on the basic paradigms of activity to be used by scientists to interpret and act on their respective fields. See Kuhn (1962, 1970) for an intensive analysis of normal and revolutionary science.

⁷ It is important to distinguish between conflict and competition, however. While conflict seems to stem from a number of the conditions we have examined or will examine—new paradigms, disagreements over goals, methodology, etc.—competition seems to have its basis in the exchange system of science. See, for example, Storer's (1966) interesting examination of the place of professional recognition and commodity exchange in the scientific community.

tige available. The conflict here is crucial. Areas whose prestige is relatively high tend to recruit members with the most talent. Relatively lower prestige areas can have quite a difficult time gaining adherents to their particular interests. Realistically, a prime factor, if not *the* most important factor, in high quality scientific research is the quality of student and scientific "labor" a specialty can recruit. Prestige has a strong influence in enticing students and the competition over relative prestige can be intense, therefore, because of these consequences (Hagstrom, p.173).

My point here is decidedly not to denigrate competition in science, nor is it to present a demonic view of the scientific enterprise in all its ramifications. Rather it is to espouse a more realistic perspective on this enterprise and the *uses of conflict among its practitioners*. Conflict and competition themselves are quite functional. They induce scientists in each area to try to establish a domain of competence in their subjects that is specifically theirs. Competitive pressures also help to assure that less popular research areas are not neglected. Furthermore, the strong competitive element in the scientific community encourages members to take risks, to outdistance their competitors, in effect, thereby increasing the possibility of new and exciting discoveries (Hagstrom, pp.82-83).

Conflict is also heightened by the very normative structure of the scientific community itself. In fact, it may be a significant contributing agent in both conflict and competition. Among the many norms that guide the behavior of scientists, perhaps the most important for our discussion here is that of organized skepticism. Storer (1966, pp.78-79) defines it as follows:

"This norm is directive, embodying the principle that each scientist should be held individually responsible for making sure that previous research by others on which he bases his work is valid. He cannot be excused if he has accepted a false idea and then pleads innocence 'because Dr. X told me it was true,' even if privately we cannot accuse him of willfully substituting error for truth; he should have been properly sceptical of Dr. X's work in the first place. . . .

The scientist is obligated also by this norm to make public his criticisms of the work of others when he believes it to be in error. . . . It follows that no scientist's contribution to knowledge can be accepted without careful scrutiny, and that the scientist must doubt his own findings as well as those of others."

It is not difficult to see how the norm of organized skepticism has contributed to the controversies within scientific communities.

Other examples of conflict abound. Perhaps the one most important for our own topic is the existence of "rebellious" subgroups in scientific communities. Specialities that revolt against the goals and/or means of a larger discipline are quite common within the scientific tradition. These rebellious groups of researchers are alienated from the main body of current scientific discourse in their particular areas and sparks may very well fly because of the argumentation between the rebels and the traditionalists. Here, often added to this situation, even the usual arguments that we associate with science—that is, arguments among groups and individuals over substantive issues such as warranted knowledge and the like—blend with arguments over goals and policies (Hagstrom, 1965, pp. 193-194).⁸ Even more importantly today, it is becoming quite common (and in my view, happily so) for there to be heated discussion and dissension over the political stance a discipline should take and over the social uses of its knowledge.

So far we have been documenting the rather important dimension of conflict in scientific communities. We have been making the point that scientific knowledge as it is taught in schools has, in effect, been divorced from the structure of the community from which it evolved and which acts to criticize it. Students are "forced," because of the very absence of a realistic picture of how communities in science apportion power and economic resources, to internalize a view that has little potency for questioning the legitimacy of the tacit assumptions about interpersonal conflict that govern their lives and their own educational, economic, and political situations. Not only are they presented with a view of science that is patently unrealistic, but, what is more important for our own position, they are not shown how critical interpersonal and intergroup argumentation and conflict have been for the progress of science. When this situation is generalized into a basic perspective on one's relation to the economic and political paradigms of activity in a society, it is not difficult to see how it can serve to reinforce the quiescence of students or lead them into "proper channels" for changing these structures.

⁸ Statistics is an interesting example.

Conflict in Society

The second area of schooling in which one finds hidden curricular encounters with and tacit teaching of constitutive assumptions about conflict, and that we have chosen to explicitly focus upon, is that of social studies. As in our discussion of science, in delving into this area we propose an alternative or broader view on conflict in society. We also document some of the social uses of intellectual and normative conflict, uses that are ignored in most of the curricular encounters found in schools.

An examination of much of the literature in social studies points to an acceptance of society as basically a cooperative system. Observations in classrooms over an extended period of time reveal a similar perspective. The orientation stems in large part from the (perhaps necessarily unconscious) basic assumption that conflict, and especially social conflict, is *not an essential* feature of the network of social relations we call society (Dahrendorf, 1959, p.112). More often than not, a social reality is pictured that tacitly accepts "happy cooperation" as the normal if not the best way of life. Now it must be made clear that the truth value of the statement that society is a cooperative system (if only everyone would cooperate) *cannot* be determined empirically. It is essentially a value orientation that helps determine the questions that one asks or the educational experiences one designs for students. And the educational experiences seem to emphasize what is fundamentally a conservative perspective.

The perspective found in schools leans heavily upon how all elements of a society, from the postman and fireman in first grade to the partial institutions in civics courses in high school, are linked to each other in a functional relationship, each contributing to the ongoing *maintenance* of society. Internal dissension and conflict in a society are viewed as inherently antithetical to the smooth functioning of the social order. *Consensus* is once more a pronounced feature. This orientation is also evident in the implicit emphasis upon students (and man in general) as value-transmitting and value-receiving persons rather than as value-creating persons in much of their school experience (Gouldner, 1970, p.193).

The fact that there are a number of paradigmatic ways one can perceive the social world has long been noted. However, it is also important to note that each posits a certain logic of organization upon social activity and each has certain, often strikingly different,

valuative assumptions that underlie it. The differences between the Durkheimian and the more subjectivistic Weberian perspectives offer a case in point. The recent analysis of structural-functional social theories, especially those of Parsons, by Gouldner offers a more current example. His examination, one that has a long intellectual history in the sociology of knowledge, raises intriguing questions about the social and political consequences of contemporary social thought—that much of its background of assumptions is determined by the personal and class existence of the thinker, that it presents a "very selective, one-sided picture of American society," one geared to "the avoidance of political tensions" and aimed at a notion that political stability, say, "would be achieved if efforts at social change prudently stopped short of changing established ways of allocating and justifying power" (p.48). In short the underlying basis of such a social "paradigm" used to order and guide our perceptions is fundamentally oriented to the legitimation of the existing social order. By the very fact that it seeks to treat such topics as social *equilibrium* and system *maintenance*, for example, there is a strong tendency toward conformity and a denial that there need be conflict (pp.210-218).

Opposed to the structural-functional type of reasoning, Gouldner advocates a different "paradigm," one that is rooted in the individual's search to transform himself and his activity, and one that sets not existing society as measure but rather the possibility of basic structural change through an individual's passionate commitment and social involvement. The question of legitimation, hence, becomes less a process of studying how institutional tensions evolve and can be "settled," and more an attempt to link institutions with their historical development and their need for transformation according to explicitly chosen principles based on political and moral argumentation. The perspective on conflict of the latter position is quite different from that of the school of thought Gouldner criticizes.

In its analysis of the background assumptions of Parsonian social thought, for example, Gouldner's examination documents the place of moral argumentation and value conflict, which are at the heart of the human sciences and their understanding of society. He thereby considerably expands the boundaries of possible conflict. This situation is perhaps most evident in his criticism of the inordinate place Parsons gives

to a socialization process that implicitly defines man as primarily a recipient of values (p.206). He censures Functionalist social theories for being incapable of dealing with "those who oppose social establishments actively and who struggle to change its rules and membership requirements." Gouldner opposes this view with a focus upon human beings as engaged in a dialectical process of receiving, creating, and recreating values and institutions (p.427; Berger & Luckmann, 1966). The continual recreation of values in a society is a difficult process and often involves conflict among those of disparate valuative frameworks. It is this type of conflict, among others, to which Gouldner attempts to give a place.

By their very nature, social "paradigms" themselves are constantly changing. In fact, Gouldner's recent work can be seen to mirror and be a part of this change. However, they leave behind reifications of themselves found in both elementary and high school curricula. This may be particularly true in the case of the models of understanding of social life we find in schools today.

There is, perhaps, no better example of the emphasis upon consensus, order, and the absence of any conflict in social studies curricula than that found in one of the more popular sets of educational materials, Science Research Associates' economics "kit," *Our Working World*. It is designed to teach basic concepts of disciplined economics to elementary school students. The primary-grade course of study subtitled "Families at Work" is organized around everyday social interaction, the likes of which children would be familiar with. Statements such as the following pervade the materials.

"When we follow the rules, we are rewarded; but if we break the rules, we will be punished. So you see, dear, that is why everyone does care. That is why we *learn* customs and rules, and why we *follow* them. Because if we do, we are all rewarded by a nicer and more orderly world." (Senesh, 1963, p.22)

The attitude exhibited toward the *creation* of new values and customs and the value placed on an orderly, nonconflicting world seem to be indicative of a more constitutive set of assumptions concerning consensus and social life. When one realizes that students are inundated with examples of this type throughout the day, ones in which it is rather difficult to find any

value placed upon disorder of any significant sort, it makes one pause.

Even most of the inquiry-oriented curricula, though fruitful in other ways to be sure, show a signal neglect of the efficacy of conflict and the rather long and deep-seated history it has held in social relationships. For example, the basic assumptions that conflicts are to be "resolved" within accepted boundaries and that continuing change in the framework and texture of institutional arrangements is less than desirable can be seen in the relatively sophisticated discipline-centered social science curricula that are being developed currently. One of these curricula (Center for the Study of Instruction, 1970) overtly offers a "conceptual schemes" approach that puts forward a hierarchy of generalizations that, ideally, are to be internalized by the student through his active participation in role-playing and inquiry. These levels of generalizations range from rather simple to fairly complex and are subsumed under a broad "descriptive" generalization or "cognitive scheme." For example, subsumed under the organizing generalization "Political organization (government) resolves conflicts and makes interactions easier among people" are the following subgeneralizations. They are listed in ascending complexity.

- "1. The behavior of individuals is governed by commonly accepted rules.
2. Members of family groups are governed by rules and law.
3. Community groups are governed through leadership and authority.
4. Man's peaceful interaction depends on social controls.
5. The pattern of government depends upon control by participation in the political system.
6. Stable political organization improves the quality of life shared by its citizens." (p.T-17)⁹

Coupled with these "descriptive" generalizations, which the students are to be led up to, are such "supporting concepts" as "Rules help to maintain order" and "Rules help protect health and safety" (p.T-26). Now, few will quarrel with these statements. After all, rules do help. But, like the assumptions prevalent in the economics material, children are confronted with

⁹ It is questionable whether many blacks in the ghettos of the United States would support this "description."

a tacit emphasis once again on a stable set of structures and on the maintenance of order.

What is intriguing is the nearly complete lack of treatment of or even reference to conflict as a social concern or as a category of thought in most available social studies curricula or in most classrooms observed. Of the more popular materials, only those developed under the aegis of the late Hilda Taba refer to it as a key concept. However, while the Taba Social Studies Curriculum overtly focuses on conflict, and while this focus in itself is a welcome sight, its orientation is on the serious consequences of sustained conflict rather than on the many positive aspects also associated with conflict itself. Conflict again is viewed as "dysfunctional," even though it is pictured as being ever present (Durkin, Duvall, & McMaster, 1969, p.v).

As we noted previously, to a large extent society as it exists, in *both* its positive and negative aspects, is held together by implicit common-sense rules and paradigms of thought. Social studies materials such as this (and there are many others to which we have not referred) can contribute to the reinforcing and tacit teaching of certain dominant basic assumptions and, hence, a pro-consensus and anti-dissension belief structure.

This view is being countered somewhat by a portion of the content now being taught under the rubric of Black Studies. Here, struggle and conflict on a communal basis are often explicitly and positively focused upon (Hare, 1969; Wilcox, 1969, pp.20-21). While many curriculumists may find such overt espousal of community goals somewhat antithetical to their own inclinations, the fact that there has been an attempt to present a comparatively realistic outlook on the significant history and uses of conflict in the progress of social groups, through the civil rights and black power movements for instance, must be recognized. Even those who would not applaud or would applaud only a rather safe or conservative view on this subject should realize the potency and positive value of just such a perspective for developing a group consciousness and a cohesiveness not heretofore possible. This point is made again in our more general discussion of the uses of conflict in social groups.

To say, however, that most Black Studies curricula exhibit this same perspective would be less than accurate. One could also point to the by now apparent presentation of black historical material where those blacks are presented who stayed within what were

considered to be the legitimate boundaries (constitutive rules) of protest or progressed in accepted economic, athletic, scholarly, or artistic fields. Usually, one does not find reference to Malcolm X, Marcus Garvey, or others who offered a potent critique of existing modes of activity. However, it is the *massiveness* of the tacit presentation of the consensus perspective that must be stressed, as well as its occurrence in the two areas examined in this paper.

It is not sufficient, though, for our purposes to "merely" illuminate how the hidden curriculum obligates students to experience certain encounters with basic rules. It is essential that an alternative view be posited and that the uses of social conflict that we have been mentioning be documented.

It is possible to counter the consensus orientation with a somewhat less consensus-bound set of assumptions, assumptions that seem to be as empirically warranted, if not more so, as those to which we have raised objections. For instance, some social theorists have taken the position that "society is not primarily a smoothly functioning order of the form of a social organism, a social system, or a static social fabric." Rather, continuous change in the elements *and* basic structural form of society is a dominant characteristic. Conflicts are the systematic products of the changing structure of a society and by their very nature tend to lead to progress. The "order" of society, hence, becomes the regularity of change. The "reality" of society is conflict and flux, not a "closed functional system" (Dahrendorf, 1959, p.27). It has been stated that the most significant contribution to the understanding of society made by Marx was his insight that a major source of change and innovation is internal conflict. This crucial insight can be appreciated without the necessity of accepting his metaphysical assumptions (Walker, 1967, pp.217-218). In essence, therefore, conflicts must be looked at as a basic and often beneficial dimension of the dialectic of activity we label society.

An examination of positions within and closely allied with this general orientation can help to illuminate the importance of conflict. One of the more interesting perspectives points to its utility in preventing the reification of existing social institutions by exerting pressure upon individuals and groups to be innovative and creative in bringing about changes in institutional activities. Coser (Dahrendorf, 1959, p. 207) puts it well:

"Conflict within and between groups in a society can prevent accommodations and habitual relations from progressively impoverishing creativity. The clash of values and interests, the tension between what is and what some groups feel ought to be, the conflict between vested interests and new strata and groups demanding their share of power, have been productive of vitality."

Yet one is hard pressed to find anything akin to this orientation in most of the materials and teaching exhibited in schools. The basic rules of activity that govern our perception tend to cause us to picture conflict as primarily a negative quality in a collectivity. However, "happy cooperation" and conflict are the two sides of the societal coin, neither of which is wholly positive or negative. This outlook is forcefully put by Coser (1956, p.31):

"No group can be entirely harmonious for it would then be devoid of process and structure. Groups require disharmony as well as harmony, dissociation as well as association; and conflicts within them are by no means altogether disruptive factors. Group formation is the result of both types of processes. The belief that one process tears down what the other builds up, so that what finally remains is the result of subtracting the one from the other, is based on a misconception. On the contrary, both 'positive' and 'negative' factors build group relations. Conflict as well as cooperation has social functions. Far from being necessarily dysfunctional, a certain degree of conflict is an essential element in group formation and the persistence of group life."

The basic rule of activity that constitutes the unconscious negative value associated with conflict tends to lead to the designing of experiences that focus on the "law or rule breaking" dimension of conflict, yet it should be made clear that conflict leads not "merely" to law breaking but is, in effect, law *creating* as well (Coser, p.126).¹⁰ It performs the considerable task of pointing to areas of needed redress. Furthermore, it

brings into conscious awareness the more basic rules that govern the particular activity over which there is conflict but that were hidden from view. That is, it performs the unique function of enabling individuals to see the hidden imperatives built into situations that act to structure their actions, thereby partially freeing individuals to create relevant patterns of actions to an extent not usually possible. These law-creating and expanding-awareness properties of conflict situations offer, in combination, a rather positive effect. Since conflict brings about inherently new situations that to a large degree are undefined by previous assumptions, it acts as a stimulus for the establishment of new and possibly more flexible or situationally pertinent norms of activity. By literally forcing conscious attention, issues are defined and new dimensions can be explored and made clear (Coser, pp.124-125).

Documentation of the positive effects of conflict would not be even nearly adequate if a major use were to go unmentioned, especially given our own commitment to making urban education, in particular, more responsive to the needs of the community it serves. Here we are speaking of the importance of conflict for both creating and legitimating a conscious and specifically ethnic experience. It is now well known that one of the primary ways groups define themselves is by perceiving themselves as struggling with other groups and that such struggle both increases members' participation in group activities and makes them more conscious of the bonds that tie them together (Coser, p.90). That the black and other ethnic communities have, to a significant extent, defined themselves along these in-group/out-group lines is of no small moment since it enables a greater cohesiveness among the various elements within their respective communities. By drawing upon "primordial sentiments" such as race a communal meaning structure is created that makes plausible an individual's and a group's continued and separate existence (Berger, 1967, pp.24-25; Geertz, 1963, p.118). Just as conflict seems to be a primary means for the establishment of individual autonomy and for the full differentiation of personality from the outside world (Coser, 1965, p.33),¹¹ so too is it effective for the full differentiation of community autonomy. Respect for pluralistic societies may require a greater acceptance of this perspective.

We have been proposing an alternative outlook on

¹⁰ Perhaps the best illustration of material on the law-breaking dimension of conflict is a primary-grade course of study, "Respect for Rules and Law" (New York State Bureau of Elementary Curriculum Development, 1969). One set of curricular materials does take some interesting and helpful steps in allowing for a more honest appraisal of conflict. See Oliver & Newmann (1968).

¹¹ This is perhaps one of Piaget's most fruitful insights.

the presence and uses of conflict in social groups. It is feasible for it to be used as a more objective foundation for designing curricula and guiding teaching so that the more static hidden curriculum students encounter can be counterbalanced to some extent. The explicit focusing on conflict as a legitimate category of conceptualization and as a valid and essential dimension of collective life could enable the development by students of a more viable and potent political and intellectual perspective from which to perceive their relation to existing economic and political institutions. At the least, such a perspective gives them a better understanding of the tacit assumptions that act to structure their own activity.

Programmatic Considerations

There are a number of programmatic suggestions that can be made that could at least partially serve to counterbalance the hidden curriculum most evident in science and social studies. While these are by their very nature still rather tentative and only partial, they may prove important.

A more balanced presentation of some of the espoused values of science is essential, especially that relating to organized skepticism. The historical importance to the scientific communities of the overriding skeptical outlook needs to be recognized and focused upon.

The history of science can be seen as a continuing dialectic of controversy and conflict between advocates of competing research programs and paradigms, between accepted answers and challenges to these "truths." As such, science itself could be presented with a greater historical orientation documenting the conceptual revolutions necessary for significant breakthroughs to occur.

Rather than adhering to a view of science as truth, the balanced presentation of science as truth-until-further-notice, a process of continual change, could prevent the crystallization of attitudes (Apple and Popkewitz, 1971). In this connection also, the study of how conceptual revolutions in science have proceeded would contribute to a less positive perspective on consensus as the only mode of progress.

To this point can be added a focus upon the moral uses and dilemmas of science. For example, personalizing the history of science through cases such as Oppenheimer, Watson, and, intriguingly, the controversy surrounding the Velikovsky case (cf. Mulkay,

1969), would indeed be helpful. When taken together, these suggestions would help to eliminate the bias of present curricula by introducing the idea of personal and interpersonal controversy and conflict.

In the social studies, a number of suggestions can be made. The comparative study of revolution, say the American, French, Russian, and Chinese, would serve to focus upon the properties of the human condition that cause and are ameliorated by interpersonal conflict. This suggestion is made more appropriate when coupled with the fact that in many countries revolution is the legitimate (in a quite real sense of the word) mode of procedure for redressing grievances.

A more realistic appraisal and presentation of the uses of conflict in the civil rights movement of blacks, Indians, and others would no doubt assist in the formation of a perspective that perceives these and similar activities as legitimate models of action. The fact that laws *had* to be broken and were then struck down by the courts later is not usually focused upon in social studies curricula. Yet, it was through these types of activities that a good deal of progress was and is made. Here community and "movement" studies by urban students of how changes have been effected is an interesting process, one that should prove of considerable moment.

Finally, the comparison of different paradigmatic views on social life and the differing value assumptions of each would be helpful. While the normative implications of many paradigms of social thought may serve to limit their usefulness as models of action, and in fact may make them totally unacceptable on occasion, the presentation and analysis of alternative conceptions to those now dominant could still be effective.

Beyond these suggestions for specific programmatic changes, one further area should be noted. Sociological "paradigms" also attempt to account for the common-sense reality in which students and teachers dwell. Schools are integrally involved in this reality and its internalization. It might be wise to consider engaging students in the articulation and development of paradigms of activity within their everyday lives at school. Such involvement could enable students to come to grips with and amplify crucial insights into their own conditionedness and freedom. Such insights could potentially alter the original paradigm and the common-sense reality itself. It would also make possible to a greater degree a concrete and meaningful educational encounter for

students with the process of value and institutional recreation.

Conclusions

Research on political socialization of children seems to indicate the importance of the president and the policeman as points of contact between children and the structures of authority and legitimacy in a society (Easton & Dennis, 1969, p.162). For instance, there is a strongly personal initial bond between the child and these representatives of the structures of authority. As the child matures, these very personal ties are transferred to more anonymous institutions such as a congress or to political activities such as voting. The tendency to lift impersonal institutions to high esteem may be quite an important source of the relative stability and durability of the structures of authority in industrial societies (pp.271-276).

Yet it is not quite certain that this formulation really answers the questions one could raise concerning political and social stability. The foundation of political (broadly conceived) leanings and relations to political and social structures is in a belief system that itself rests upon basic patterns of assumptions. Such rules for activity (and thought as a fundamental form of this activity) are probably more important to a person's relation to his life-world than we realize. We have been examining one of these constitutive assumptions.

It is our contention that the schools systematically distort the functions of social conflict in collectivities. The social, intellectual, and political manifestations of this distortion are manifold. They may contribute significantly to the ideological underpinnings that serve to fundamentally orient individuals.

Students in most schools and in urban centers in particular are presented with a view that serves to legitimate the existing social order since change, conflict, and man as creator as well as receiver of values and institutions are systematically neglected. We have pointed to the massiveness of the presentation. Now something else must be stressed once again—the fact that these meaning structures are obligatory. Students receive them from persons who are “significant others” in their lives, through their teachers, other role models in books and elsewhere. To change this situation, students' perceptions of to whom they are to look as holders of “expert knowledge” must be radically altered. In ghetto areas, a partial answer is, perhaps, instituting a more radical perspective in the schools.

This change can be carried out only by political activity. It may very well be that to divorce an educator's educational existence from his political existence is to forget that as an act of influence, education is also an inherently political act.

One of the primary tasks of this analysis has been to present lenses that are alternatives to those that normally legitimate many of the activities and encounters curriculum designers design for students. The curriculum field has limited its own forms of consciousness so that the political and ideological assumptions that undergird a good deal of its normal patterns of activity are as hidden as those that students encounter in schools (Huebner, 1962, p.88). We have pointed to the possibilities inherent in a more theoretically realistic approach to the nature of conflict as one alternative “form of consciousness.” Yet when all has been said, it is still possible to raise the question of whether such theoretical investigations are either heuristically, politically, or programmatically helpful.

One of the difficulties in seeking to develop new perspectives is the obvious and oft pointed to distinction between theory and practice or, to put it in common-sense language, between “merely” understanding the world and changing it. This distinction is rooted in our very language. Yet it is crucial to remind ourselves that while, say, Marx felt that the ultimate task of philosophy and theory was not merely to “comprehend reality” but to change it, it is also true that according to Marx revolutionizing the world has as its very foundation an *adequate understanding* of it. (After all, Marx spent most of his lifetime writing *Das Kapital*—Avineri, 1968, p.137).

The significant danger is not that theoretical thought offers no mode of critiquing and changing reality, but that it can lead to quietism or a perspective that, like Hamlet, necessitates a continuing monologue on the complexity of it all, while the world tumbles down around us. It would seem important to note that not only is an understanding of existing reality a necessary condition for changing it (Avineri, p.148), but it is a major (and perhaps the major) step in actually effecting this reconstruction. However, with this understanding of the social milieu in which curriculum designers operate, there must also be a continual attempt to bring to a conscious level those hidden epistemological and ideological assumptions that help to structure the decisions they make and the environments they design (Huebner, 1962).¹² These funda-

mental assumptions can have a significant impact on the hidden curriculum in which students tacitly dwell.

Without an analysis and greater understanding of these latent assumptions, educators run the very real risk of continuing to let values work through them. A conscious advocacy of a more realistic outlook on and teaching of the dialectic of social change would, no doubt, contribute to preparing students with the political and conceptual tools necessary to deal with the dense reality they must face. I do not think it is necessary to enumerate the possible consequences if this self-evaluation should not occur.

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¹² The common-sense assumptions that seem to posit a rather static logic upon curriculum design also seem to cohere with a type of bureaucratic rationality that has had a long tradition in curriculum thought. For an excellent analysis of this tradition, see Kliebard (1971).

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